

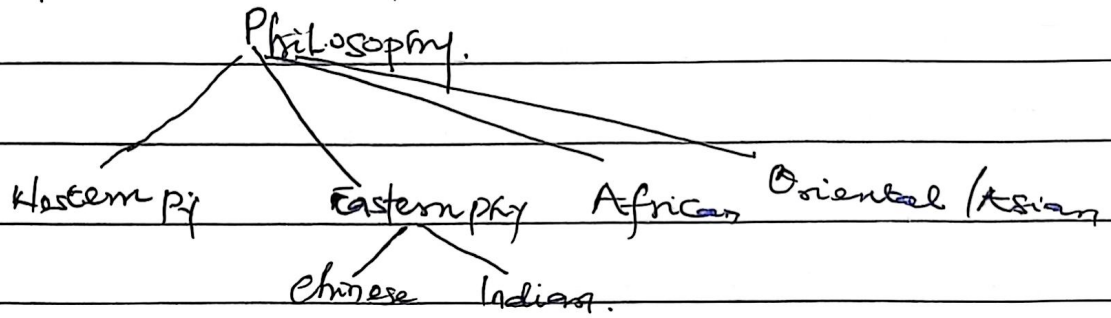
The idea of this course is majorly based on word "issues". This is because it is presupposed that you have gained some knowledge in African philosophy hence should be able to address issues and raise questions in African philosophy.

Course Contents.

- Philosophy and the need for contextualization.
- Universalism and Particularism debate.
- Meaning and Justification of African Logic.
- African Metaphysics.
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- Concept of Causality.
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- African philosophy and the Challenge of Cultural relativism.
- Evaluation.

05-03-2025

"Philosophy and the need for contextualization"



"CONTEXT"

This word is very essential in this course, it refers to situatedness, particularization, specification and focusing on particular framework.

Some schools of thought came up with the argument that there should be a focus on just philosophy without seeking to particularize or focus on any group by contextualizing philosophy to the group. They considered contextualization as frivolous.

Another school of thought disagreed with ~~the~~ just focusing on philosophy as a whole. For them particularization and contextualization is essential since it gives relevance to the group ~~of~~ in which a particular group ~~also~~ made their philosophical ~~argument~~.

These two schools of thought address an issue in philosophy called "Particularist/Universalist debate". This issue is very

essential to our course, and would enable us to unravel the need for African philosophy.

UNIVERSALIST

These people are of the opinion that the underlining element that makes us humans is reason, which is possessed by people from various groups. Hence for them, if we all have the same reason, why the particularisation (note:- they do not argue about the degree of rationalist)

Also, for them even though human experiences may differ, they do not deny human experiences, nevertheless for them the humanness which every person shares is what gives birth to those experiences hence should take precedence.

They also argued that the goal of human philosophy is to enable us to understand ourselves everywhere, which contextualisation challenges through fragmentation.

PARTICULARIST

These people or school of thought are of the opinion that ^{Knowledge} philosophy is content-dependent. The knowledge of people are based majorly on their consent.

'African predicament'

↳ Inheriting an education
that makes you believe that
you are what the west says
you are.

3 M

They argue that it makes sense to talk of different philosophies because it is based on context. For them context gives us the instrument to approach reality; to ignore context damages the totality of what makes a people.

These particularist also argue that philosophical problems and engagements should not be superficial (superficial). This is because the goal of philosophical discusses is to address problems and there is no problem or issue that has a general perspective. Hence, philosophy in addressing human concerns should focus on particular issues of a people and not addressing it from a universal perspective.

They argued also that the more we ~~see~~ particularize, the more we allow knowledge to expand. We enrich philosophy by focusing on the context of various groups, this particularization does not limit philosophy but makes it to develop more.

12-03-2025

The Question of alternative epistemology. (African Epistemology)

Epistemology

Knowledge refers to the claim we have on knowledge,

how do we know, what do we know and the validity of what we claim to know. Epistemology focuses on analysis and evaluation of the claim of knowledge, This claim/definition is valid for all people as well as to particularist and universalist.

However, if the claim to knowledge, what need is there for African epistemology different from that of the general meaning of epistemology.

One of the positions that support this need is the fact that each group has their various sources of knowledge, what contributed to the claim to knowledge is different from others, since each group have various categories, environment, background and situation which contributes to the formation of knowledge.

Also mental faculties are formed differently depending on their specific environment, geography, environment and background.

Therefore, it is valid that though epistemology is a claim to how we know, there is still a need for alternative

epistemology. (Finding a balance/middle point b/w 'Particularist' and 'Universalist')

Alternative epistemology refers to taking notice of the background, geographical location, culture, human upbringing that influence and inform the capacity to reason. It takes into account that there are different factors, influences, and experience involved in training the mental faculty. These influences contribute to how people make attempts to know and how they know.

We can therefore comfortably delve into African epistemology which is given credence by alternative epistemology. Here we deal with the process African epistemology had gone and what it brings to the table of general discussion. There are two divisions of African epistemology; Early stage and Later stage.

EARLY STAGE.

African Epistemology:- The ways in which an African comes to know, process what he knows, it is that branch of philosophy that tries to understand the various process and influences that determine how African claim to know and how their knowing processes is developed. However, even though epistemology as the study of knowledge is universal, the way people acquire knowledge, and the way they ^{make claims to knowledge} ~~knowledge claims~~ varies according to their socio-

Cultural context, geographical challenges, lived experiences, influences and environment.

Those who defend African epistemology argue that concepts like knowledge, truth and rationality can be interpreted taking cognisance of the individual context. Hence the African cultural context is indispensable to the way they come to knowledge.

Therefore African epistemology is the attempt of African to focus on the particular differences and influences that enable an African to make claims to knowledge.

1. Early Beginning:- African Epistemology = African ontology.

+ Tempels, Senghor, Idowu, Mbiti, Kagame e.t.c.

Views:- Emphasis on uniqueness of African ontology

- Knowledge is tied to that unique ontology.

2. Later attempts: Professional African philosophers who champion conceptualization and theorization.

2 Strategies: 1. Use of western concepts and categorization to interpret African experiences

2. Focus on home-grown concepts and categories in the study of African Epistemic System.

mbiti - time

Senghor - different structure of thought that makes us work

Early Beginnings/Stage - This stage was championed by white priest who focused on the philosophical nature of the African culture. Placide Tempels a Belgian priest played a major role in this stage. He looked at the Baka culture of the Congo people and tried to understand how specific the approach to their interpretation of reality. He did something different from other missionaries by freeing himself from the limit of reasoning which the Westerners placed on Africans.

The champions of this early stage argued that African epistemology is equivalent to their ~~as~~ ontology. For them emphasis is on the uniqueness of African ontology, they argued that African epistemology and approach to knowledge is tied to their ontology. Among these proponents, includes Tempels, Senghor, Idowu, Mbiti and Kagame.

They argued that because in every society that Africans have a particular way of interpreting reality, their epistemology is included in that interpretation. Mbiti did this in his analogy of time, which he argued that African concept of time is not as linear as the Westerners.

Senghor argued that have a different mental structure which guide their interpretation of reality. He referred to this as

Negotiable. For him this makes African different since they are more emotional blending the reason and emotion unlike the Westerners.

Koigame lived among the Rwandas and understood that the language structure they have is different and unique to them. For him this difference in language underlines their understanding of reality which in the same sense fashion their epistemology and claims to knowledge.

Later Attempts:- They were more interested in developing African epistemology by focusing on conceptualization and theorization. They were divided into two groups/strategies; the first group argued in developing African epistemology by making use of Western categories and concepts in explaining African epistemology. On the other hand, the second strategy argued that instead of making use of Western categories, Africans should develop home-grown concepts and categories particular to Africans in order to explain African epistemology.

However, these two approaches/strategies are good; what African epistemology needs is to be able to blend the two strategies. Being able to make use of home-grown categories and concepts and blending the Western ^{categories} ~~categories~~ with it. ~~The~~

These latter attempts focus on growing the African categories and concepts while at the same time making a clear understanding of the Western categories.

The efforts by African philosophers to develop African epistemology challenges the paradigm of Western epistemology, which has been taken as universal standard, that impedes or disregards the recognition of all non-Western epistemologies or paradigms or modes of knowing.

26-03-2025

AFRICAN METAPHYSICS.

African Metaphysics is carved out aspect of the whole branch of metaphysic. Metaphysic as a branch of philosophy is concerned with fundamental questions of reality, it is concerned with essence, space and time, cause and effect. Metaphysics occupies itself with an attempt to fashion, what is real and what is not real. It ~~also~~ asks ontological questions about ultimate reality.

African Metaphysics propose however that the African has a particular way in which he questions ultimate reality based on his lived experiences and conceived environment. Therefore the justification of African metaphysics is based on the question "Is perception universal or particular". People differ in the experiences as such their perceptions differ, therefore it makes sense to speak of African Metaphysics as a distinctive way African perceive reality.

Perception are influenced by multiplication of factors such as:-

1. Expectation
2. Beliefs.
3. Emotions

Mechanistic model - Just things as they appear.

Teleological model - Going beyond what is seen (the end)

4. Conception scheme.

5. Histories and Social Circumstances.

6. Language (vehicle / instrumentum laborem for perception)

WHY AND HOW OF AFRICAN METAPHYSICS

Metaphysical discuss on Africa must be based on African reality, determined by perception of, history, geographical circumstances and other cultural phenomenon such as religion, linguistic conventions and thought systems entrenched in the African world view

African Metaphysics is distinguished from Western Metaphysics based on two models; Mechanistic model and Teleological model. The mechanistic model explains the effect in reality with another existing reality that is seen, while teleological models explains reality based on something beyond reality and cannot be not just visible. While African Metaphysics ~~is~~ focuses more on the teleological model, Western metaphysics focuses on the mechanistic model.

Features of African Metaphysics.

1. African metaphysics places religious beliefs at the center of its ideas, relating to the African conception of God, the universe and their inter-relations. It is characterized by the fact that there is

an unseen force behind reality.

2. There are peculiar notions such as spirit, causality, space and time and various other speculations that underline the interrelatedness of the object of reality.

3. African Metaphysics is ~~holist~~ holist in nature; it is all encompassing, as such there is an interrelatedness of all experiences. It is all embracing in the inter-connectedness of things. Within this holistic feature of African Metaphysics, reality is seen as a close system where everything hangs together and is affected by any change in the system. The bulk of the subject matter within this holistic system falls under what western conception would refer to as supernatural.

4. Unlike the Western counterpart, African metaphysics doesn't admit of dualism between natural vs supernatural, matter vs mind/spirit/soul.

5. African metaphysics has a strong empirical flavour

6. African Metaphysics is built on the assumption that the universe is complex and that the humankind and its world constitutes an environment much deeper than what human senses can perceive.

7. Causality plays a central role in African Metaphysical thinking. - After, while Western Metaphysical thinking follows the mechanistic model, African Metaphysics on the other follows more the teleological model of thinking.

8. There is a complete rejection of Chance in African Metaphysics, because there is always a teleological explanation of everything in reality.

9. African metaphysics is pragmatics, it gives priority to that which works over theoretical coherence.

African Metaphysics is growing like every other discipline, therefore it is not static and unchanging. It is necessary to ensure future discussions that would shed new lights on African Metaphysics to the extent that it can answer adequately the lived experiences of the African man.